Character Analysis Project:

Negan's Diagnosis (The Walking Dead)

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Summary

The Walking Dead is a TV series created by Robert Kirkman and Tony Moore as a horror survival show centered around humans adapting to the aftermath of a zombie outbreak. A group of survivors led by a recent coma patient sheriff Rick Grimes are forced to adapt to their new infected environment as they try to live out their lives in fear of both "walkers" and unknown human assailants. Over time, group members are lost to walkers and gang members and more take their place, as they are told that there is no cure to the outbreak and people who die or are bitten will turn undead. They are forced to move from one safe haven to another, as they are constantly overrun and threatened by outside forces, though they eventually split up to then come back together in what becomes a larger community. This cycle repeats, revealing more and more separate communities until the main group encounters Negan and the Saviors gang, who hold them captive while Negan kills two more of their members. He and his crew harass and constantly threaten the main group until they finally attempt to kill Rick and their plans are foiled, with Negan almost being killed by him, marking his switch from a villain to an anti-hero-style character.

As this show has an insanely large cast of characters, only the longest running/most important cast members and the authors will be listed:

Authors:

- Robert Kirkman
- Frank Darabont
- Glen Mazzara

- Scott Gimple
- Angela Kang

Cast of Common Characters:

- Rick Grimes – Andrew Lincoln
- Lori Grimes – Sarah Wayne Callies
- Carl Grimes – Chandler Riggs
- Michonne Grimes – Danai Gurira
- Shane Walsh – Jon Bernthal
- Carol Peletier – Melissa McBride
- Maggie Rhee – Lauren Cohan
- Eugene Porter – Josh McDermitt
- Rosita Espinosa – Christian Serratos
- Gabriel Stokes – Seth Gilliam
- Ezekiel Sutton – Khary Payton

Character Investigation

Season 6, Episode 16

The chosen one for this paper is Negan, as his introduction marks the beginning of the display of his Borderline Personality Disorder. As he speaks to Rick (S6 E16), Negan's words, after capturing a whole group of people who were trying to provide medical attention to one of their own, are, "You work for me now. You have [stuff], you give it to me, that's your job." He repeats by threatening them, saying that they aren't safe and will end up even worse if they don't give him half of their supplies. At first, Negan says "I don't want to kill you," but then declares that the group must be punished for killing his men (who, for reference, were already trying to sap supplies from Rick's community in the first place). To enforce the rule, he then randomly picks two people and murders them while forcing the entire group to watch. Even after recognizing what everyone had to experience, Negan continued to smile incessantly through the entire ordeal. To murder someone is already a crime, but to have nearby witnesses watch everything and still grin insensitively in response to them displays unstable and very manipulative behavior, as this whole event transpired because the victims defended themselves from Negan's thieves in the first place, which in his mind allowed for a twisted sense of vengeance with the end goal of taking their resources from them.

Season 7, Episode 1

Negan drags Rick into his van when Rick vows to kill him, to which Negan then plays with his emotions by encouraging him to grab a nearby axe and stay true to his word. He tries, but Negan quickly shuts him down and presses him back to the ground, telling him to "remember

what happened and remember what could still happen." He is now threatening Rick's community, forcing Rick to remember the murder of his group members by putting him in a similar situation, and further lowering his mental stability all in one scene. While driving on through the morning, Negan makes a walker splat onto his windshield to then taunt Rick by asking, "Remind you of anyone you know?", thoughtlessly joking about the murders. He then goes up to Rick and says, "You are mine. The people back there? They are mine. This," as he holds up a possession of one of the victims, "This is mine." He then pushes Rick into a horde of zombies to grab that possession, all the while threatening his group continuously by repeating, "Get me my axe, Rick! Remember what can still happen!" When they both return to the camp, Negan goes a step further and holds everyone at gunpoint while ordering Rick to chop off his own son's left arm. Even when the other members express that they already understand what he wants in an attempt to stop the insane order, Negan responds with, "I know you do, but I don't know if Rick does," in an act of showing indifference to those pleading for mercy. When Rick finally caves, Negan stops him and shows him that his work is done, with Rick's face being full of fear. Continuing to meet the end goal, Negan forces Rick to recite a pledge of his people and services to him and then loads up one of the members into another van while saying, "I like him. He's mine now." The common theme of taking what isn't his by force is one of the main reasons for his diagnosis, as although many people would choose to take items by force, Negan chooses to physically and verbally beat fear and submission into his victims just to get what he wants without any regard for their emotional responses or mental stability.

Disorder Analysis

The National Library of Medicine describes borderline personality disorder as “a severe mental illness marked by unpredictable feelings, behaviors, and relationships” with symptoms including “emotional instability, impulsivity, and poor social connections” (Mishra, Rawekar, Sapkale, 2023, p. 9). This disorder sometimes causes the manipulation or disregard of others with the mindset of personal gain, which is what makes Negan a prime example of this disease. Although attempts to treat the condition have become more successful, a cure is not yet possible. In people who suffer from BPD, they express very strong emotional responses and increased emotional sensitivity compared to others (Miller, 2024, p. 9). This could cause very dangerous behavior, with diagnosed people who are naturally aggressive reacting with physical force in response to certain social expressions: “People with BPD are often overwhelmed by intense anger and feelings of abandonment, emptiness, shame and self-loathing” (Miller, 2024, p. 9), so it’s important not to judge those who are diagnosed with this illness, since the source may not be as obvious as the person’s emotional responses.

Borderline personality disorder shares some association with symptoms of Major Depressive Disorder, but MDD “commonly co-occurs with BPD.“ (Beatson, Rao, 2013, p. 9). If a teen were to consistently feel detached from their parents and easily get into arguments with them over small, at one point insignificant issues in response to peaceful gestures or small chores, they could end up diagnosed with either BPD or MDD, since both disorders have similar symptoms. Distinguishing between these two illnesses is a necessary task for medical professionals to understand because diagnosing a patient with the wrong one may end up with them taking a prescription medication (and suffering from the side effects of those meds) and

losing knowledge on how each one really works. To help discover patients' symptoms easier, Dr. Miller supports the idea that "it's crucial to get someone who develops symptoms into treatment as soon as possible" to "lessen inaccurate diagnosis of more common disorders like ADHD, depression, and bipolar disorder," though there is still a small chance that these could happen at the same time as BPD.

Borderline personality disorder can also cause an extreme need to "escape extreme emotional distress," so diagnosed patients might "use things like cutting, scratching and opening wounds to alleviate emotions they find tolerable" (Miller, 2024, p. 9). This self-destructive behavior is unfortunately one of the main methods used to compensate for the constant powerful emotional forces manipulating their actions, but there are safer ways to curb the pain than self-harm. AnneMarie Churchill, a CTRI resource, prescribes understanding the severity of suicide and talent before taking any drastic measures. She also suggests that supportive people nearby maintain their own self-care while also displaying confidence to the disordered to make them feel better about themselves and their condition, almost like the member that Negan captures after they attempt to defend their friends from him. The same way he admired their effort is similar to how people who suffer from BPD will show admiration and often decreased symptoms in the presence of someone who shows respect and confidence to or around them. Playing music and exercising can also be used to redirect or cancel out the overwhelming flow of emotions, along with searching for emotional support through social activities or small conversations with others (Salters, 2023, p. 9). Salters says that safely coping with BPD will "build confidence in your ability to handle difficult situations" and "reduce the likelihood that you will do something harmful to attempt to escape from the emotional distress," the second of which Negan might have avoided if he tried these methods. There are numerous ways to counter this psychological

condition through therapy, with some therapeutic sessions being dialectical behavior therapy (for self-harm behaviors), schema therapy (for negatively impacted life patterns due to the illness), and group therapy (which uses similar patients in groups to lessen the impact of the problem) (Mishra, Rawekar, Sapkale, 2023, p. 9).

BPD is a very socially and personally impacting mental disease that is becoming increasingly recognizable as more psychologists work to understand it. With the encouragement of patients to come forward and be diagnosed before the disorder makes itself a lethal issue, a cure may appear through the combination of therapy and few medications to allow for less situations like what Negan pushed onto others, as he was not diagnosed with the disorder and thus mixed his emotional responses with his natural instinct to survive, creating a terrifying and emotionally unstable character in The Walking Dead while showing other patients how dangerous this condition really is.

References

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